

LOVELEEN TANDAN, 36

“Mickey Rourke pecked me on the cheek and said ‘Hello sweetheart!’”

An ex-boyfriend has come out of the woodwork to cash in on her new found fame. A woman in Los Angeles has started a campaign that she should have been nominated for the Best Director Oscar along with Boyle. She's also got directing offers, some screenplays adapted from novels and based in the subcontinent, and some totally unrelated to India. “After the example Danny has set for me, I can't even say, I can't do this because I'm not familiar with the culture.” The first international screening she went to was at the London Film Festival in October.

Then it was New York, back to Mumbai to work on the dubbed version, and then the BAFTAs in London. She's excited about the recognition she's got from her seniors. “Mira Nair came for the New York premiere hosted by the Indo-American Arts Council.

After the screening, she said she's very proud of me.” The co-director of the film is now grappling with offers to be represented by global agents. “I'm scared. It's like I've suddenly grown up.”

Din to Parinda, he is finally having his global moment under the zariwala neela aasman. “Life's a circle. Some day everything you've done will come back,” he says. So he's excited that the producers have given him 1 per cent of the *Slumdog* gross in perpetuity because he pledged his fees to his favourite charity, Plan India.

“Larry King told me you have milked the role,” says Kapoor. Indeed, he has also really milked the PR machinery, with the West realising he is the biggest star in the ensemble. He's trying to be the go-to-guy for Hollywood productions in India, with a daughter, fresh from New York University, into production; a son studying screen writing in Los Angeles, and his eldest daughter a bona fide movie star. The superbright Peter Rice of Fox Searchlight is a friend now, as is Michael Lynton, CEO, Sony Pictures. So in between fielding emails from Roberta Armani on what to wear for the Oscars, he is busy assuring Aditya Chopra that he will be available for Shimit Amin's next film.

It's mediocre at best

India is not Somalia. We are a nuclear power and have made better films about slums.

Let's get this straight. I have no problem with *Slumdog Millionaire* shooting the slums of Mumbai. I have an issue with its version of realism. Jamal is electrocuted all night and in the morning he's as fresh as a daisy? Amitabh Bachchan's chopper has no other place to land than in the shitpots of Juhu? And you call that a riot? It's as if it was photographed by a child. The entire movie has been badly shot. The compositions are bad, the tones are poor. I think movies such as Shankar's *Nayak*, Mani Ratnam's *Bombay* and Ram Gopal Varma's *Satya* have shot slums much better. What saved the film is A.R. Rahman's score which is rooted in India and Resul Pookutty's sound effects which have



(L TO R) KHEDEKAR, ALI AND ISMAIL

got everything right, from the soundscape of Mumbai trains to the voices in the crowd. And what is it about our culture? When a foreigner calls us slumdogs, we listen? And when an Indian calls a barber by his name, we protest? It's nothing but a mediocre Bollywood film, which has used references from several Hindi films very smartly. And it's because every country sends its best films to the Oscar except us. What do we send? *Eklavya*. All the Academy wants is drama that hits the heart directly, which we don't give them. If *Slumdog Millionaire* is winning accolades internationally it is only because they know no better. India is not Somalia. We are one of the foremost nuclear powers in the world, our satellites are roaming the universe. Our police commissioner's offices don't look like shacks and there are no blind children begging in the streets of Mumbai. This is absolute and intentional exploitation of India.

The writer is a well-known Indian filmmaker



PRIYADARSHAN